

Social Proof Playbook

Most social proof in service businesses happens by accident, when a client remembers to say something nice and you remember to save the screenshot. The strongest systems make proof a scheduled byproduct of the service itself. This playbook walks through the three capture points inside any client engagement where proof can be engineered in: intake, midpoint, and closeout. It ends with a Proof Calendar you fill in for your own business.

INTAKE

Before delivery begins. Capture baselines and expectations.

MIDPOINT

During the engagement. Capture emotion and momentum.

CLOSEOUT

At service completion. Capture the outcome in their voice.

1 Intake Capture Set

Ask these four questions at the moment a client signs the agreement, before delivery begins. The answers create a baseline you can reference at closeout, and they surface the client's own language so the later testimonial writes itself.

1. Have you worked with a provider in this category before?

Baseline for later contrast. Reveals their reference points.

2. If yes, what did you love most, and what did you find frustrating?

Surfaces language you can echo in a testimonial after you've improved on both.

3. What made you decide to work with us specifically?

Direct proof quote for case studies, sales pages, and onboarding copy.

4. What would have to be true by the end of this engagement for you to feel we exceeded your expectations?

The measurable outcome that becomes the testimonial headline at closeout.

STAGER EXAMPLE

Send these four questions as a short digital form within 24 hours of contract signing. Ask both the listing agent and the seller to answer, because the seller's language is often warmer and more personal than the agent's, and you'll want both for different uses later.

Capture Points 2 & 3

2 Midpoint Capture

Schedule one short check-in while the client is still inside the experience. Emotion is easier to capture in flight than in hindsight, and midpoint quotes often make the most compelling testimonials because they're written while the client is actively excited about the work.

1. What's working well so far, in your words?

Captures the language of progress before the outcome is known.

2. What surprised you about the experience?

Differentiation language. The surprise is usually what sets you apart.

3. If a friend asked you about us right now, what would you tell them?

The unpolished referral script in their own voice.

STAGER EXAMPLE

For stagers, the midpoint moment is the day the staging is complete and photos go live, before the listing goes under contract. Send a text or short email with the three questions and capture the answer before the house sells, which is when the client is still reacting to the transformation itself rather than the sale price.

3 Closeout Capture Set

Treat the closeout as a scheduled event on your calendar with a camera already set up. Run it as an in-person video session when your team has capacity, drop to a video call when scheduling in person isn't realistic, and use a written form only as a fallback when the other two aren't possible. The structure is what matters. When closeout is on the calendar from day one, the client expects it and shows up ready to give you real answers.

1. What was the outcome, in specific numbers if possible?

The headline. Numbers travel further than adjectives.

2. How does this compare to what you experienced before, or expected?

The before/after that creates your visual case study.

3. On a scale of 1 to 10, how would you rate the experience, and why that number?

NPS-style score plus the reasoning behind it.

4. What would you tell someone on the fence about working with us?

Objection-handling language you can reuse in sales conversations.

5. What would you tell someone who has never used a service like ours at all?

Top-of-funnel language for people who don't know they need you yet.

STAGER EXAMPLE

For stagers, run closeout on closing day when possible. Ask: days on market before the home went under contract, final sale price versus the agent's comp without staging, experience rating from 1 to 10, what they'd tell a realtor who hasn't staged a home yet, and what they'd tell a realtor on the fence about working with you. Capture on video if you have team capacity, video call if not.

4 The 7 to 14 Day Follow-Up

Between seven and fourteen days after closeout, convert the captured answers into public reviews. The work is already done because the client gave you the quote in their own words at closeout. Your job is to send it back with a link and a tiny ask.

EMAIL TEMPLATE

Subject: Quick favor if you have 60 seconds

[Name], your answers from our wrap-up made my week. With your permission, we'd love to share what you said publicly so other [client type] can find us the way you did. Would you be open to leaving a short review at one of the links below? I've pasted your exact quote so you can copy, tweak, or rewrite it.

[Platform 1 link] · [Platform 2 link]

Your quote: [paste exact words from closeout]

Incentive structure

Thank you for trusting us. — [Signature]

The incentive matters less than the ease of the ask itself. If you offer one, keep it small and brand-appropriate: a branded gift, a referral credit for their next introduction, or a small discount on future work. Never pay directly for a review, which violates platform terms on Google and Yelp.

Platform priority by business type

Local service (stagers, gyms, home services): Google Business, then industry directory (Houzz, Thumbtack, Yelp), then Facebook.

Online and digital service: LinkedIn recommendations, Trustpilot or G2, your own testimonials page.

High-touch B2B: LinkedIn post from the client, a short case study on your site, and a named reference for sales calls.

STAGER EXAMPLE

For stagers, prioritize Google Business and Houzz because realtors check both before hiring. Instagram comments from the seller are a bonus layer for social discovery. Ask the agent for a LinkedIn recommendation too, not a review, to widen where your proof shows up.

5 Your Proof Calendar

Map each capture point to a specific step in your own service delivery. Fill this in once and it becomes the working document you build your intake form, midpoint email, and closeout agenda around.

CAPTURE POINT	WHEN	WHO OWNS IT	FORMAT
1. Intake	_____	_____	_____
2. Midpoint	_____	_____	_____
3. Closeout	_____	_____	_____
4. Follow-up	_____	_____	_____

Once proof is built into the service delivery, you stop chasing it. You spend the rest of the year collecting the output the calendar already scheduled.